

**Picturesque
Representations
of the
Dress and
Manners
of the Chinese**

**by
William Alexander**

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE COSTUME
OF CHINA ***



THE
COSTUME

of
CHINA

by
W. Alexander
F.S.A. &c.

CHINA—PLATE 1

PICTURESQUE
REPRESENTATIONS

OF
THE DRESS AND MANNERS

OF THE
CHINESE.

ILLUSTRATED IN
FIFTY COLOURED ENGRAVINGS,

WITH DESCRIPTIONS.

BY WILLIAM ALEXANDER.

LONDON:

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PLATE I.
FRONTISPIECE.

EXHIBITING the various kinds of weapons, offensive and defensive, in use among the Chinese infantry, cavalry, artillery, and bowmen, arranged on a stand or frame of wood. One or more of these frames are commonly to be met with at the military posts and at the depôts of arms and guard-houses, close to the gates of their walled cities.



CHINA—PLATE 2

Plate II.

KIEN LUNG.

KIEN Lung was the fourth Emperor of the Tartar dynasty, which now possesses the throne of China. When the annexed Sketch was taken he was eighty-three years of age, but had all the appearance of a hale, vigorous man of sixty. Indeed his whole life had been spent in the active discharge of public business, and in the violent exercise of hunting and shooting in the wild regions of Tartary, which he continued with unabated zeal almost to the period of life above mentioned. He always commenced public business at two or three in the morning, and gave audience to foreign ambassadors at that early hour, whether in winter or summer, and he generally retired to rest at sunset; and to this invariable habit of rising and retiring at an early hour, he attributed much of his healthy and vigorous constitution.



CHINA—PLATE 3

Plate III.

THE FISHING CORMORANTS.

THE Leu-tzé, or fishing cormorant of China, is the *pelicanus sinensis*, and resembles very much the common cormorant of England, which, we are told by naturalists, was once trained up to catch fish, pretty much in the same manner as those of China are. They are exceedingly expert in taking fish, and pursue them under water with great eagerness. They are taken out, on the rivers and lakes, in boats or bamboo rafts; and though sent on the chase after long fasting, they are so well trained that they rarely swallow any of the fish they take until they are permitted to do so by their masters. Many thousand families in China earn their subsistence by means of these birds.



CHINA—PLATE 4

Plate IV.

A MAN SERVANT.

WE have little to observe on this figure. His dress is pretty nearly that of the class of people to which he belongs. The Chinese are excellent domestic servants, and when honest, which is a quality not common among them, they are invaluable. They are rather slow, and do not like to be put out of their way, but they do their work well and neatly. Every European resident at Canton and Macao has Chinese servants, which on the whole, are preferable to any other race of Orientals. They are sometimes brought over to England, but are seldom happy till they get back to their own country, which has the same kind of charm to them as the vallies of Switzerland had to the natives of that once happy country.



CHINA—PLATE 5

Plate V.

A MANDARIN

IN HIS COURT DRESS.

ALL officers of state, whether civil or military, from the highest to the lowest, have been named by the early Portuguese writers *mandarins*, from a word in their own language, *mandar*, to command; and this name, improper as it is, has preserved its ground ever since. The figure of a bird on the embroidered breast-plate of the annexed figure points him out as a civilian. A military officer wears the figure of an animal resembling the tiger. The degree of rank, whether civil or military, is marked by a small globe on the top of the cap, opake red coral distinguishing the highest, and brass the lowest rank: the intermediate colours are transparent red, opake and transparent blue, opake and transparent white. As a mark of imperial favour, one, two, or three feathers from the tail of the peacock are appended to the back part of the bonnet. All officers, whether civil or military, invariably wear thick-quilted boots, and, when in their court-dresses, embroidered petticoats. Most of them wear chains of coral, or agate, or coloured glass round the neck, as in the annexed figure.



CHINA—PLATE 6

Plate VI.

AN OFFERING IN THE TEMPLE.

THE figure kneeling before the deities mounted on pedestals is a priest of the sect of Fo. He is burning incense, or rather paper that is covered over with some liquid that resembles gold. Sometimes, in lieu of this, tin foil is burnt before the altars of China, and this is the principal use to which the large quantities of tin sent from this country is applied. On the four-legged stool is the pot containing the sticks of fate, and other paraphernalia belonging to the temple, and behind it is the tripod in which incense is sometimes burned. These superstitious rites are performed several times by the priests every day, but there is no kind of congregational worship in China. The people pay the priests for taking care of their present and future fate.



CHINA—PLATE 7

Plate VII.

A JUGGLER,

PERFORMING TRICKS WITH JARS.

THIS engraving exhibits a posture-master balancing two large China vases, and throwing himself into most extraordinary attitudes; he exhibited a variety of curious postures before the Ambassador, at his lodgings opposite to Canton, and played with the large jars precisely in the same manner as the Indian jugglers, in Pall-mall, toss about the large round stone of twelve or fourteen pounds weight; but those who have seen both are inclined to give the palm to the Chinese.



CHINA—PLATE 8

Plate VIII.

CHILDREN COLLECTING MANURE.

THE collecting and preparing of manure of various descriptions, and making it up into cakes for sale, occupy a very considerable population of the lowest class of society, and for the most part is the employment of the aged and children. No agriculturists, perhaps, understand the value of manure better than the Chinese, and certainly none are so well skilled in the economical distribution of it. It is quite ridiculous to see the avidity with which young children follow a traveller on horseback for the chance of catching what the animal may emit, which is immediately caught up, and thrown into the basket; and if the traveller himself should contribute his portion, it is considered as more valuable than that from the animal.



CHINA—PLATE 9

Plate IX.

A WATCHMAN.

THE police is so well regulated in all the large cities of China, that disturbances rarely, if ever, happen during the night. The watch is set at nine, and continues till five in the morning. A gate is placed at each end of the cross streets, which are all streight, and at right angles with the main streets; from each gate a watchman proceeds till he meets his brother watchman about the middle; at every half hour he beats the hollow bamboo tube, in his left hand, with the mallet in the right, striking the same number of blows as there may be half hours elapsed from nine o'clock: the blow gives a dead, dull sound, sufficiently audible, and to a stranger sufficiently disagreeable. Each watchman is also furnished with a paper lantern. At the great gates of cities, and at certain distances in the main streets are guard-houses, at which a party of soldiers are stationed to aid the police, if necessary; but this is rarely the case, as, in addition to the common watch, every tenth housekeeper in every street is made responsible for the orderly good conduct of his nine neighbours. In the day time there is plenty of noise, and quarrelling and scuffling among the lower orders of the Chinese.



CHINA—PLATE 10

Plate X.

A LADY, AND HER SON.

THE annexed print is the representation of a Chinese Lady, and her Son, of a certain rank in life, from which no high ideas will probably be entertained of the taste in dress either of one or the other. Our modern notions of a head-dress, however, approximate those of the Chinese; though it is to be hoped that our ladies will never be brought to imitate the small and mutilated feet of the Chinese women, which disqualify them from the free use of their limbs.



CHINA—PLATE 11

Plate XI.

A BONZE.

THE priests of *Fo* in China are the same as the priests of *Boudh* are in India, from whence their religion passed into China in the first century of the Christian æra. The temples and the monasteries of China swarm with them; and they practice, ostensibly at least, all the austerities and mortifications of the several orders of monks in Europe, and inflict on themselves the same painful, laborious, and disgusting punishments which the faquirs of India undergo, either for the love of God, as they would have it supposed, or to impose on the multitude, as is most probably the real motive. In China, however, they are generally esteemed as men of correct morals: and there is reason to believe, that the calumnies heaped upon them by the Catholic missionaries are for the most part unfounded, and were occasioned by the mortification they experienced in finding their ceremonies, their altars, their images, their dress, to resemble so very nearly their own.

It is scarcely necessary to observe that our umbrellas are borrowed from the Chinese. The poorest person has one of these machines to keep off the rain; but in China they are made of paper, and the wood part is entirely of bamboo. The hats of the common people are in fact a kind of umbrella; they are generally made of rice straw plaited, and so large that they equally defend the face from the rays of the sun and cover the shoulders from the rain. That which the priest carries under his arm is small in proportion of some of those worn by the peasantry. In moderate weather a Chinese, though close shaved, except as to the little lock of hair growing from the crown, generally goes bareheaded.



CHINA—PLATE 12

Plate XII.

A VENDER OF LANTERNS.

THERE is no nation so fond of illuminations and fire-works as the Chinese, and no nation has exerted its skill so effectually in the multitude of contrivances to exhibit light. Their lanterns are as various in shape as in materials. The most common are of painted paper. The most beautiful and ornamental of silk gauze, finely painted and stretched on frames that are not deficient in carving and curious workmanship, and decorated with tassels of silk of various colours. Other lanterns are round and cylindrical, and of one single piece of thin transparent horn, sometimes of an immense size. At certain times in the year, but more particularly in the month of February, they celebrate what has been called the Feast of Lanterns, when every body in the street carries some transparency or other made in every possible form: some of them like fishes, some like beasts of various kinds, and others birds. Some resemble trees and shrubs, with flowers and fruits, each in their appropriate colours. Those lanterns borne by the man in the print are of the most ordinary kind.



CHINA—PLATE 13

Plate XIII.

A SOLDIER WITH HIS MATCHLOCK.

THE military of China differs, as every thing else differs, from that of all other nations, in the nature of its establishment, its occupation, and its dress. They have two distinct armies, if they may be so called; the one composed entirely of Tartars, who are stationed in the several provinces on the Tartar frontier, and occupy all the garrison towns of the empire; the other composed of Chinese, who are parcelled out in the smaller towns and hamlets to keep the peace, by acting as constables, subordinate collectors of the taxes, guards to the granaries, and assisting in various ways the civil magistrate. Along the public roads, canals and rivers, are placed, at certain intervals, small square guard-houses, at which are stationed from six to twelve men, who are employed in settling disputes upon the rivers or roads, and also in conveying the public dispatches. When a foreign ambassador or any of their own mandarins travel, these soldiers turn out in their holiday dresses with their streamers stuck in the back, as in the annexed figure. The breast-plate and shoulder-guards are nothing more than cotton stuffed with wadding, and the helmet, which looks so fierce, is made only of paste-board. The Chinese matchlocks resemble so much the old common matchlock of the Portuguese, that it has been supposed these people first introduced them into China, where however it is sufficiently determined, gunpowder was in familiar use many centuries before any communication was known to exist between this country and Europe. In some of the larger matchlocks there is a fork to support the piece, and by sticking it in the ground to give it the degree elevation that may be required.



CHINA—PLATE 14

Plate XIV.

A PORTER CARRYING GOODS.

It has long been known that the ingenious Chinese, taking advantage of the constancy with which the wind blows in the same direction, applied a sail to assist the progress of their land carriages; but the late British Embassy has furnished us with the precise manner in which these sails are applied, and it appears that they are meant only to aid a sort of wheelbarrow, different however in its structure; that in the present drawing resembling very much the same machine which is used in the Western world, and differing from that which has already been given in a former volume exhibiting the Costume of China.



CHINA—PLATE 15

Plate XV.

A MANDARIN

IN HIS COMMON DRESS.

THE official habits in which all the mandarins are compelled to appear in public being made of the thickest silk, are exceedingly cumbersome, and not well adapted for the summer months, which are excessively hot even in the most northerly provinces; they therefore in private take every opportunity of throwing off their ceremonial garb, and assume a thin loose gown, tied with a belt round the waist. Their summer-hat is also made of light rice straw. The head is not encumbered with hair, which all ranks and ages shave close off, leaving only a small lock hanging down behind. The use of fans is universal. Even the military, when drawn out on parade-duty, make use of fans. It will be observed in this figure, that the spectacles worn by the Chinese are considerably larger than ours: they are made of cristal, glass being a species of manufacture unknown in China.



CHINA—PLATE 16

Plate XVI.

A BOAT GIRL.

ON all the rivers and canals of China a vast number of families live entirely in their boats, and the women are generally quite as efficient navigators as the men, particularly in rowing and steering. Their dress differs very little from that of the men, except about the head, on which the hair is suffered to grow freely, and is sometimes plaited behind like that of the men, as in this figure, but more frequently tied up in a knot upon the crown of the head. Among persons of this description the feet are allowed to grow to their full size, and they are almost invariably without shoes or other cover. They smoke tobacco and chew the betel and areca nut with as much avidity as the men.



CHINA—PLATE 17

Plate XVII.

A COMMON SEDAN CHAIR.

THIS is one of the most common of sedan chairs, used by the peasantry; though there are others still meaner, and without any covering over head. The wages of labour are so low, and the price of provisions so cheap, that any man above a common labourer can afford to be carried in his chair.



CHINA—PLATE 18

Plate XVIII.

A MANDARIN'S SERVANT ON HORSEBACK.

THE annexed is a portrait of a true Tartar horse, which seems to be pretty much of the same breed as those of the Cossacks. The Chinese horses are precisely of the same kind. In fact, no pains whatever appear to be taken either for improving the breed, or by attention to their food, cleanliness, or regular exercise, to increase the size, strength, or spirit of the animal. A currycomb, or any substitute for it, is unknown in China. Indeed horses are not much in use. Wherever the nature of the country admits of canals or navigable rivers, travelling and conveyance of every kind are principally performed on the water. A single horse suffices to draw a mandarin's carriage, which is nothing more than a little covered cart without springs.



CHINA—PLATE 19

Plate XIX.

AN ITINERANT MUSICIAN.

THE Chinese have full as great a variety of musical instruments as most other nations, but they are all of them indifferent, and the music, if it may be so called, produced out of them, execrable. The merit of our travelling musician consists in beating a sort of tambourine, or rather a shallow kettle-drum, with a mallet held between the toes of one foot, while he strikes a pair of cymbals with the other, and, at the same time plays upon a sort of guitar accompanied by his voice. It would seem also that he is equally skilled in wind instruments, of which a flute and trumpet make their appearance out of the mouth of his bag; a pair of rattles connected by a piece of riband lie on the ground, and near them a hollow piece of wood, nearly heart-shaped, which, when struck with a mallet, emits a dull disagreeable sound, like the hollow bamboo carried by the watchman, for which this is sometimes substituted. A Chinese band always play in unison, and never in parts: this indeed is an art they have not yet reached, and those few who have heard European harmony pretend to dislike it. A Chinese ear is best gratified with the sounds of noisy instruments, as gongs, kettle-drums, shrill trumpets, jingling bells and cymbals, or with the faint and reedy tones, scarcely audible, of a little bamboo organ, which swell and die away not unlike those of an Eolian harp.



CHINA—PLATE 20

Plate XX.

AN OFFICER OF THE CORPS OF BOWMEN.

THE original weapon of the Chinese, which by the way seems to be the offensive arms of most savages, is the bow. It is still preferred by them to the matchlock; and the Tartars are so fond of it, that it forms an essential part of the education of the young princes of the blood. Their bows are large, and require a considerable degree of strength, as well as a peculiar knack to string them. Even the Emperor wears a ring of agate on the right thumb for the string to press against in drawing the bow, which is the weapon he uses every summer in hunting tigers and other wild beasts in the forests of Tartary. When the troops are drawn out on parade-duty, not only the superior officers carry colours, but a small flag is stuck on the back of every fifth, seventh, or ninth man. The characters on the flag generally designate the rank of the bearer and the name of the corps.



CHINA—PLATE 21

Plate XXI.

A CHINESE MENDICANT.

BEGGING is by no means a profitable trade in China, and few therefore pursue it except the monks of Fo and Tao-tzé, and a few impostors who go about pretending to foretell events and predict good or ill fortune. The annexed is the representation of a beggar of a different description. The piece of hollow wood in his hand is struck to draw attention, and the label on his back describes his condition, which is not exactly such as in other countries would excite much compassion. It states his unfortunate situation, as having no children to take care of him, to console him in affliction, to give him food when hungry, or medicine when sick. The want of children is considered in China as the greatest of all misfortunes, and is in reality so, as by the moral precepts of that nation, which have all the force of law, filial piety is looked upon as the first of moral virtues; and, however poor a child may be, he is bound to share his earnings with his aged parents.



CHINA—PLATE 22

Plate XXII.

CHINESE BARBERS CHAMPOOING, &c.

THROUGHOUT all the East, in India as well as in China, the luxury of champooing is enjoyed by all ranks of men; it consists of pulling the joints until they crack, and of thumping the muscles until they are sore; it is generally an operation performed by the barbers, who at the same time cleanse the ears, tickle the nose, and play a thousand tricks to please and amuse their customers, to whom and the surrounding audience they tell their gossiping stories. Of their merit in this respect we have abundant information in the Arabian Nights Entertainments.



CHINA—PLATE 23

Plate XXIII.

A BOOKSELLER.

IN so arbitrary a government as that of China, it would scarcely be supposed that the press should be free; that is to say, that every one who chooses it may follow the profession of a printer or a bookseller without any previous licence, or without submitting the works he may print or expose for sale to any censor appointed by government; but then he must take his chance to suffer in his person all the consequences that may result from the impression that may be made on the minds of the civil officers as to the tendency of the work. A libel against the government, an immoral or indecent book, would subject both printer and publisher to certain punishment both in his person and purse. The Chinese have not made any great progress in literature, and still less in the sciences: they most excel in the history of their own country, in morality, and in practical jurisprudence. Their dramatic works are constructed on the same model as those of the Greeks, to which it is hardly necessary to add they are infinitely inferior. Their novels and moral tales are better; but the works in most esteem are the four classical books supposed to be written or compiled by Confucius. Their printing is not performed by moveable types, like ours, but by wooden blocks the size of the page; and this mode appears to have been in use long before the Christian æra.



CHINA—PLATE 24

Plate XXIV.

A SOLDIER OF INFANTRY.

THE annexed figure, either from the striped dress, or the furious looking head painted on the shield, has been called a tiger of war; but he is not so fierce as he appears to be, or as the name would imply; indeed the Chinese admit that the monstrous face, on the basket-work shield, is intended to frighten the enemy, and make him run away; like another Gorgon's head to petrify those who look upon it. This corps of infantry, in its exercise, assumes all kinds of whimsical attitudes, jumping about and tumbling over each other, like so many mountebanks. Indeed the whole of the Chinese military tactics are as absurd as they are ridiculous. When an army is drawn out, it must represent the heavens, or the earth, or the moon, or the five planets, or the five-clawed dragon, or mystical tortoise. Père Amiot, a French missionary, has been at the trouble of collecting or composing the military tactics of China, which fill a large quarto volume.



CHINA—PLATE 25

Plate XXV.

A RAREE SHOW.

THERE is every reason to believe, that Punch and his wife were originally natives of China; and that all our puppet-shows were brought from that country. The little theatre, above the head of a man concealed behind a curtain, is precisely Chinese. *Les ombres Chinoises* still bear the name of their inventors; but the annexed representation of a puppet-showman is somewhat different from both, and is the simple origin of the *Fantoccini*, which consists in giving motion to the puppets, by means of springs attached to particular parts of the figures. These little dancing puppets are not merely exhibited for the amusement of children; they furnish entertainment for the Emperor and his court, and more especially for the ladies who, from their recluse mode of life, are easily diverted with any kind of amusement, however childish. We find from Mr. Barrow, that a puppet-show was one species of entertainment given to Lord Macartney and his suite at the Emperor's palace of Gehol in Tartary.



CHINA—PLATE 26

Plate XXVI.

A MANDARIN'S PAGE.

WE have not much to observe with respect to the annexed figure. He is the page or body servant of a mandarin, to carry his papers, his writing apparatus, the cushion on which he sits, or lays his head; he takes care of his areca-box and his tobacco pipe, attends him on all occasions, fans him while asleep; and, if report speaks truth, serves him for other unworthy purposes. Every mandarin has one or more of these kind of boys whom, even in public, they treat with a familiarity which is not quite decorous. The upper vest, worn by the person in the annexed figure, is of fur, which in all the northern provinces is found to be absolutely necessary in the severe cold of the winter months.



CHINA—PLATE 27

Plate XXVII.

A TRAVELLING SMITH.

IT is a peculiar feature in all the Oriental nations, that the most beautiful specimens of workmanship in the various arts are made with the most simple and at the same time most clumsy tools. The artificers moreover are rarely fixed, or settled in a workshop convenient for their purposes, but generally travel about the country carrying their shop and apparatus with them. The annexed figure represents an itinerant smith, who has more tools than almost any other artificer of China, and yet performs his work the worst. Their cast iron is light and good, but their manufactures of wrought iron are very indifferent: they can neither make a hinge, nor a lock, nor even a nail that can be called good. The bellows of the smith is a box with a valvular piston, which, when not in use, serves as a seat, and also to contain his tools. The barber also makes a seat of his basket; the joiner uses his rule as a walking-stick, and the same chest that holds his tools serves him as a bench to work upon: such are the expedients which thousands resort to, both in India and China.



CHINA—PLATE 28

Plate XXVIII.

VISIT TO THE GRAVE OF A RELATION.

FILIAL piety in China extends beyond the grave. Every year at certain periods dutiful children assemble at the tomb of their parents or ancestors, to make oblations of flowers, or fruit, or pieces of gilt paper, or whatever else they consider as likely to be acceptable to the manes of the departed. Their mourning dress consists of a garment of Nanquin cotton, or canvas, of the coarsest kind. Some of the monuments erected over the dead are by no means inelegant; like their bridges and triumphal arches, they are very much varied, and made apparently without any fixed design or proportion. The semicircular or the horse-shoe form, like that in the print before which the mourner is kneeling, appeared to be the most common.



CHINA—PLATE 29

Plate XXIX.

A SELLER OF RICE.

ALMOST every necessary of life, and many articles that are not of that description, are carried about the streets for sale, and the invariable mode of bearing burthens of this kind is in baskets or boxes suspended from the two extremities of a bamboo lath, swung across the back part of the shoulder. If a Chinese should only have one basket to carry, he is sure to get a log of wood, or a large stone to counterpoise it at the opposite end, thus preferring to carry a double weight rather than place it on the head, or the shoulder, or across the arm. The Chinese are in appearance far from exhibiting any signs of great muscular powers, but in lifting, or carrying a load, they are probably not excelled by the porters even of Ireland.



CHINA—PLATE 30

Plate XXX.

A FEMALE COMEDIAN.

It is, perhaps, more proper to call the annexed figure, the representation of a person in the character of a female comedian, than “a female comedian,” as women have been prohibited from appearing publicly on the stage since the late Emperor, Kien Lung, took an actress for one of his inferior wives. Female characters are now therefore performed either by boys or eunuchs. The whole dress is supposed to be that of the ancient Chinese, and indeed is not very different from that of the present day. The young ladies of China display considerable taste and fancy in their head-dresses which are much decorated with feathers, flowers, and beads as well as metallic ornaments in great variety of form. Their outer garments are richly embroidered, and are generally the work of their own hands, a great part of their time being employed in this way. If it was not a rigid custom of the country, to confine to their apartments the better class of females, the unnatural cramping of their feet, while infants, is quite sufficient to prevent them from stirring much abroad, as it is with some difficulty they are able to hobble along; yet such is the force of fashion, that a lady with her feet of the natural size would be despised, and at once classed among the vulgar.



CHINA—PLATE 31

Plate XXXI.

A SEDAN BEARER.

WHENEVER the Emperor of China goes in state to transact public business, to receive ambassadors, or to hold a court, he is carried in the same kind of a sedan chair as are commonly used in Europe, and which, as well as umbrellas, have obviously been first introduced from China. The soft luxury of an Indian palanquin is unknown to the Chinese. By means of poles attached to each other the Emperor's chair, on grand occasions, is carried by eight pair of bearers, sometimes by four pair, but on ordinary occasions he has no more than two pair. They are generally the stoutest and tallest men that can be found, and are dressed in a long yellow vest, which is the colour assumed by the imperial family.



CHINA—PLATE 32

Plate XXXII.

A MAN SELLING BETEL, &c.

THE practice of smoking tobacco is not more common, at least in the southern provinces of China, than that of chewing the areca nut, mixed with chunam, or lime made of shells, and wrapped up in a leaf of the betel pepper. Indeed this compound masticatory is in universal use throughout all India, the Oriental Islands, Cochin-china, and Tonquin. In addition to the little purse which every Chinese wears suspended from his belt as an appendage to his tobacco pipe and to hold the ingredients for smoking, whether tobacco, or opium, or both, he generally carries another to contain areca nuts broken into small fragments: the other materials, the betel leaf, and chunam are to be met with in every little eating shop, and on almost every stall in the bazar, or market, and are among the most common articles carried about the streets for sale. The areca tree is one of the palm tribe, with a tuft of leaves surmounting a stem as straight and beautifully shaped as the shaft of a Corinthian pillar. It requires a warm climate, and grows freely in the southern provinces of China, but is common in every part of India and the Oriental Islands.



CHINA—PLATE 33

Plate XXXIII.

A CHINESE CARRIAGE.

THIS machine, like a baker's cart, is the kind of wheel carriage which is most common in the country, and such as even the high officers of state ride in, when performing land journies in bad weather, and the driver invariably sits on the shaft in the aukward manner here represented. They have no springs, nor any seat in the inside, the persons using them always sitting cross-legged on a cushion at the bottom. In these carts the gentlemen of Lord Macartney's embassy who had not horses, were *accommodated*, over a stone pavement full of rutts and holes. When ladies use them, a bamboo screen is let down in front to prevent their being stared at by passengers, and on each side, the light is admitted through a square hole just large enough for a person's head.



CHINA—PLATE 34

Plate XXXIV.

A MAN WITH PIPES FOR SALE.

THE very general use of tobacco throughout the whole extensive empire of China, and the still more extensive regions of Tartary, would seem to contradict the commonly received opinion, that this herb is indigenous only in America. One can hardly suppose that the Chinese, who are so remarkably averse from the introduction of any thing novel, would, in the course of three centuries, have brought the custom of smoking into universal use; yet so it is; men of all ranks and all ages; women, whatever their condition in life may be, and children even of both sexes of eight or ten years of age, are furnished with the necessary apparatus for smoking tobacco. In walking the streets, in almost all the occupations of life, the tobacco pipe is seldom out of the mouth. When not in use it is placed in a small pouch suspended from the girdle; and another appendage is a small silken purse generally attached to the pipe for containing opium, areca nut, or some other masticatory. The tube of the pipe is generally made of bamboo, and the cap or bowl of the metal called tutanague or porcelain. The shape and structure of this machine are strongly marked with originality, being unlike those in use among any other people; but the plant itself is, we understand, of a different species to any of those found in America, which is perhaps the strongest proof of all, that the custom of smoking has existed in China from time immemorial.



CHINA—PLATE 35

Plate XXXV.

A WATERMAN IN HIS BARGE.

SOME millions of Chinese live entirely on the water, in boats and barges of various kinds, some occupied in carrying articles of provisions and merchandize, others in conveying passengers, some in feeding and rearing ducks, and others in fishing. Some of these vessels have masts and sails, others are forced forwards with large sculls or pushed on with poles, some are dragged along by men, and others, but very rarely, by horses. Near the head of each vessel is suspended in some convenient place, one of those noisy instruments well known in this country by the name of gong, which is used to regulate the motions of the trackers, and to give notice to other vessels of the approach and intentions of the one that beats the signal. Where a large fleet is about to come to anchor or make fast for the night, there is a tremendous crash of gongs from all quarters; the meaning of each of which is distinctly understood by the Chinese, from the peculiar mode in which each is struck.



CHINA—PLATE 36

Plate XXXVI.

A TRADESMAN WITH HIS SWAN-PAN.

THE Chinese merchants and tradesmen are most expert and ready reckoners; but they perform all arithmetical operations mechanically, by means of a table divided into two compartments, through which pass iron wires; and on these wires are strung in one compartment five, and in the other two, moveable balls. The principle is something of the same kind as that of the *abacus* of the Romans, and is with some little variation still made use of in Russia. It has been observed, that in weighing several thousand chests of tea, or bales of goods, at Canton, the Chinese accountant can invariably name the sum total long before the European can cast up his account.



CHINA—PLATE 37

Plate XXXVII.

FEMALE PEASANT.

BLUE or brown cotton frocks with green or yellow trowsers are the ordinary dresses of the female peasantry, all of whom, except such as labour in the field or the fisheries, have the vanity to cramp their feet, in imitation of their superiors. Those in the print are employed in winding cotton yarn. They are, in general, ill featured, and their countenance void of expression.



CHINA—PLATE 38

Plate XXXVIII.

A TARTAR DRAGOON.

OF the Tartar horse another specimen has been given in this work. This represents a Tartar dragoon armed with the common instruments, the bow, and a short sabre. This corps is probably of little use beyond that of carrying dispatches, and assisting in the imperial hunts in the forests of Tartary. All the cavalry that were seen by the British Embassy had a mean, irregular, and most unsoldierlike appearance.



CHINA—PLATE 39

Plate XXXIX.

PUNISHMENT OF THE *TCHA*, OR CANGUE.

THE punishment of the cangue may be compared to that of our pillory, with this difference, that in China a person convicted of petty crimes or misdemeanours is sometimes sentenced to carry the wooden clog about his neck for weeks, or even months; sometimes one hand, or even both hands, are inserted through holes, as well as the neck. The annexed representation is not a common one, and far less painful than the plain heavy tablet of wood, the whole weight of which must be supported on the shoulders; whereas in this it is mere confinement, without the person being compelled to carry a heavy load. The nature of the offence is always described in large characters, either on the edge of the cangue, or, as in the present instance, on a piece of board attached to it.



CHINA—PLATE 40

Plate XL.

CHILDREN EATING THEIR MEAL.

AMONG the peasantry and labouring people of China, all are cooks. A little earthen-ware stove and an iron pan is all that is required. Rice is their principal food, which is simply boiled, and then a little fat of pork or a salt fish put into the pan to mix with it and give it a relish; they drink little else besides water, which is usually carried about in a gourd slung on the back; and they require no table nor chairs. Each person has his bowl and his chopsticks, and squatting down on his haunches before the pan, he makes a hearty and contented meal. It is quite gratifying to see a party of youngsters making their dinner in this way in the open air.



CHINA—PLATE 41

Plate XLI.

A SEDAN CHAIR.

THE vehicles of this description are nearly as various in the different provinces of China, and among the different ranks of inhabitants, as their boats and barges are. The one here engraved belongs to a person in a certain rank of life, probably an inferior mandarin. It will be observed that, instead of carrying the poles in the hands, as we do, the Chinese carry the chairs on the shoulders by means of a cross-bar fixed to the poles by straps: but different kinds of chairs are carried in different ways.



CHINA—PLATE 42

Plate XLII.

VIEW ON THE GREAT CANAL.

THE grand canal of China, or rather the water communication between the northern and southern extremities of the empire by a succession of canals and rivers, is certainly the first inland navigation in the world. The multitude of vessels, of every size and shape, is not to be estimated. The large one in the print is one of those which carried the British ambassador and his suite up the Pei-ho to the neighbourhood of Peking, which were in every respect comfortable and commodious. On passing bridges, which are very frequent in the neighbourhood of all towns and villages, the masts are usually lowered down; but many of the bridges are lofty enough to admit the smaller kind of barges to pass underneath with their masts standing. The bridges are almost as various in their shape and construction as the barges, and some of them by no means destitute of taste.



CHINA—PLATE 43

Plate XLIII.

A CHINESE LADY OF RANK.

IF we except the unnatural custom of maiming the feet, which swells and distorts the ankles, and wrapping the latter up in bandages, the dress of Chinese ladies in the upper ranks of life is by no means unbecoming. In the head dress, in particular, they sometimes exhibit great taste, and great variety; and the materials of which their garments are made, and especially those parts of them which consist of their own embroidering, are exceedingly beautiful. Confined by education in their mental acquirements, a great part of their time is employed in works of this kind, in looking after and cultivating plants growing in pots which decorate their apartments and inner courtyards, and in attending to birds, which are either kept for singing, or some particular beauty of form or plumage. The buildings in the back ground form part of a view of Peking, near one of the western gates.



CHINA—PLATE 44

Plate XLIV.

A NURSERY MAID AND TWO CHILDREN.

THE annexed are portraits of a female servant, and of a male and female child, which will give a tolerably correct idea of the dresses worn by them respectively. That of the maid servant differs in nothing from her mistress, but in the materials; the latter generally wearing silk, and the one in question cotton. A Chinese woman of the meanest condition would feel herself degraded if not allowed to mutilate her feet.



CHINA—PLATE 45

Plate XLV.

A STAGE PLAYER.

By the military emblem on the breast-plate, the annexed figure of a stage player must be intended to represent a great general or some military hero famous in the annals of China. Noisy music and extravagant gestures are the characteristic features of the Chinese stage, of which it would lead us into too long a detail to convey any intelligible account; and we prefer, therefore, to refer to the curious and interesting descriptions which have been furnished on this subject by Lord Macartney, Sir George Staunton and Mr. Barrow. We have only to add, that the figure was sketched from the life.



CHINA—PLATE 46

Plate XLVI.

TRACKERS REGALING.

THERE is little to observe on the annexed engraving. It represents a groupe of the common peasantry of the country eating their rice. The particular employment of these, here designated, is that of tracking barges on the canals; the pieces of wood lying by them being those which they place across the chest to drag forward the vessels. It will be seen from the other prints, that the common mode of carrying burthens is that of swinging baskets from the two extremities of a bamboo, which is laid by the middle across the shoulders.



CHINA—PLATE 47

Plate XLVII.

A MANDARIN'S OFFICER.

THIS gentleman is a sort of appendage to a man in power. Some half-dozen of them generally precede a mandarin of rank when he goes in procession, but more especially when he attends a tribunal of justice. Their peculiar province seems to be that of keeping off the crowd. The feathers they wear in their tall conical hats are from three to six feet in length, and are apparently the tail feathers of a peculiar species of pheasant, which is represented as very scarce. Some of them wear the tail feathers of the argus pheasant.



CHINA—PLATE 48

Plate XLVIII.

PUNISHMENT FOR INSOLENCE TO A SUPERIOR.

PIERCING the ear with various sharp instruments is among the punishments of the Chinese. A man who had been insolent to one of the suite of Lord Macartney's embassy, was sentenced to receive fifty strokes from the pant-zee or bamboo, in addition to having his hand pinned to his ear by an iron wire, which was said to have been inflicted immediately after the bastinado.

The middle figure is an inferior officer of the police, who holds a painted board on which the crime is exhibited to spectators; the other personage is a mandarin reproving the culprit.



CHINA—PLATE 49

Plate XLIX.

WOMAN SELLING CHOW-CHOW.

THERE is little more to be observed of the present engraving than this: that whatever wares, goods, or merchandize are exposed to sale in the open air, which in the open plains, as well in the broad streets of cities, is very much the case, the vender and the articles themselves are, during the summer months, protected from the rays of the sun by a large umbrella, which is generally square, like that in the print. Some hundreds of similar stands and umbrellas were displayed on a plain near the spot where the embassy disembarked, within the mouth of the Pei-ho; the little booths, if they may be so termed, being generally well stored with sweet-meats and sliced water-melons laid upon ice. The poorest peasant in China carries an umbrella, either to defend him against the rays of the sun, or heavy rains.



CHINA—PLATE 50

Plate L.

A MILITARY POST.

AT certain distances, more or less remote according to the nature of the country, along the roads, and the banks of the interior navigations, are placed small parties of soldiers from five or six to a dozen, and sometimes more. They are employed in conveying the public dispatches, and in assisting the magistrates to quell disturbances. The immense army of China is for the most part parcelled out in this way. Near each of these posts is a tall wooden building from whence they can see and communicate by signals with the next stations. The men till the ground, and perform other kinds of labour; but are always expected to turn out in their holiday dress when an ambassador or any of their *ta-zin* or great men happen to pass the station, on which occasion they generally fire three little petards stuck into the ground with the muzzle upwards as a salute.

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